Images of Mother India on the stage, repeated chants of ‘Bharat Mata ki Jai’ and ‘Vande Mataram’ had persuaded some government ministers and officials to believe that the agitation was being propped up to target the central government politically. The presence of a few RSS leaders and volunteers on stage had only added to this suspicion. The strong presence of Sri Sri Ravi Shankar’s Art of Living supporters had given what one government minister called a ‘saffron edge’ to the movement. ‘Anna is only a prop—the real power is with the RSS,’ Digvijaya Singh told me in an interview at the time.

He wasn’t entirely off the mark. The RSS had decided to support the Anna agitation sensing an opportunity to embarrass the UPA government. Sri Sri’s own role was suspicious as well. I had met the Art of Living guru for the first time during the Dharam Sansad at the Kumbh Mela in Allahabad in 2001. Then, along with other VHP-supported sants and sadhus, he had joined the demand for a Ram mandir in Ayodhya.

Since then, I had occasionally met ‘Guruji’ at the prodding of his followers, many of whom were wealthy and powerful women. ‘He is truly a man of God,’ is how one of his devotees described him. Dressed in signature white robes, long hair flying halo-like around his head, he appeared to exude calm. He once held my hand, looked in my eyes and asked, ‘Are you happy, really happy?’

He may have been offering spiritual solace, but he was surely looking for a greater role for himself in public life. Be it Ayodhya, Kashmir or the Naxal issue, Sri Sri often tried to have his say. The anti-corruption movement offered him another chance. Sri Sri, according to some accounts, was to have been the original ‘face’ of the anti-corruption movement. ‘He was very close to the Sangh Parivar and wanted us to negotiate with the BJP leaders. Once, when we refused, he flew into a rage,’ recalls a Team Anna member.

But the Centre’s reservations over the nature of the anti-corruption movement didn’t stop it from initiating a dialogue with the Team Anna leadership. Here again, the UPA would stumble into a muddle. When Anna’s fast took off, a decision was taken at a meeting in the PMO to